slide or to get more severe" with China.[97] Speaking to the Indian parliament, he emphasized that US forces "serve not only ourselves but friends and allies who, like us, have perceived the danger."[98] Subsequently, addressing a half-million-strong audience, he asserted, "we who are free must support each other." These statements left observers scrambling to interpret whether that meant that the US would defend India in the case of a Chinese attack. Eisenhower's staff subsequently issued a clarification that assistance had neither been requested nor promised.[99] The *New York Times* correspondent in Delhi predicted, however, that if China and India did go to war there was "no question that India would have to seek military assistance—and would get it from the United States at once." In the meantime, even if India did not want military aid, it certainly wanted Eisenhower's "heavy moral support" on the question. Furthermore, it still wanted economic assistance for development, which, Nehru continued to assert, was the best way to deal with the long-term threat from China.[100]

Nehru indeed valued the moral support and publicly noted that Eisenhower, coming as he had at "this special hour," had struck a deep chord.[101] He also appreciated the president's private assurance that he would not allow Pakistan to "stab India in the back" if India was engaging China on the battlefield.[102] From Washington, Indian embassy officials reported that Sino-Indian developments had made an impression on the US public too. "Smug satisfaction" had given way initially to fear that a weak India would give in to China and then to a determination to stand by India as it stood up to China.[103]

These developments also led Eisenhower to approve further covert action to support Tibetan resistance operations to harass Beijing and help the Tibetan and free world cause.[104] Available evidence suggests that, at the very least, India was aware of—and did not quite object to—some US activities. Dutt, for example, asked US ambassador to India Ellsworth Bunker about American violations of India's air space and American arms that had been found with Tibetan refugees. He accepted American excuses on the latter and expressed the hope that any future American airdrops would not cross Indian air space. Bunker interpreted this conversation as not disapproving of US actions, but stemming from concern that this might negatively affect Indian public opinion of the US and weaken Delhi's hand vis-à-vis Beijing.[105]